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Introduction

Why Critical Reading Matters

I SAID IN THE preface that we live in an age of deliberate deception. But we also live in what may be a golden age of nonfiction. The one statement being true doesn't make the other false; both conditions can obtain simultaneously. There will be time enough to document the range and quality of contemporary writing about the real world, so for now, let's simply say that there is a vast array of very good and even much great nonfiction writing. Which is why I also suggested that we need to be able to separate the sheep from the goats in the books and articles we read. In other words, we need to read critically, or more critically than we currently do. First, though, let's consider the nature of nonfiction and what it might mean to read critically.

Ever since I began thinking about this project, a question has dogged my steps, because I knew someone would ask: when a book has been written on a subject, why is there a second one? Why are there hundreds of books and articles on the Battle of the Little Bighorn rather than just one? Why, after the *definitive* biography of, say, Abraham Lincoln (and there have been several

so deemed) do biographies keep coming? We know that the feted one is definitive; every review will have told us so. Their appearance suggests that perhaps the Big Bio did less defining than some of us thought. So why do they exist? Because at some point, human beings are involved: in the life or event or turmoil being discussed, as well as in the writing of said discussion *and* in the evaluation of that writing.

We can never know the innermost thoughts of another person. Heck, we barely know our own. In the case of the Battle of the Little Bighorn, there were three persons we would most want to hear from. The most celebrated of the three, based on bookshelves and the history of movies and television shows, George Armstrong Custer, was unavailable to file an after-action report. All we can know of General Custer's thoughts is whatever he shared with others before the battle, and history tells us that most of those thoughts were wrong. So, what about the native leaders, Lakota chiefs Sitting Bull and Crazy Horse? Sitting Bull was a holy man, a visionary, rather than a battle chief. He was not present at the battle, although he said his dreams depicted the manner of Custer's downfall and gave the war leaders a strategy to follow. Crazy Horse, who was a battle chief and is generally credited with leadership in the victory, went on the run for most of the following year. When he finally surrendered, in May 1877, he probably sealed his fate, which was to be killed four months later. So details of who decided on what course of action and why are a little thin.

And there, Dear Reader, is why we need the second book. And the third, the fourth, the two hundred and seventy-first. Nobody gets it all correct and complete. Space is limited, information nearly the opposite. What one leaves in or out is a subjective mat-

ter more than an editorial one. Maybe, just maybe, one person's bias will cancel out an earlier one's, or more complete knowledge will fill in gaps in earlier versions, and we can eventually get closer to something resembling objective truth. Which we can never achieve.

A friend of mine, upon hearing of this project, said, "When I got to college, I believed that nonfiction meant that the thing was true." Ah, we were so naive then. Well, why wouldn't she? The nonfiction writing that she—and you and I and pretty much everyone everywhere—encountered most often growing up was the textbook. And if we can't count on textbooks, whose contents we are tasked with absorbing and then handing back on tests, to be true, then where are we? Nowhere, that's where. We count on the explanations for an algebraic equation or the date of a battle to be accurate, that chlorine and sodium will indeed react in a certain way, that amphibians do indeed live their early lives where chapter three says they do. Otherwise, all is lost. We learn to trust our textbooks, if for no other reason than we need to pass the upcoming test. That strategy serves us well during our school days, but it doesn't necessarily translate well to the world of general nonfiction, where we might be best served by President Ronald Reagan's policy when dealing with the Soviet Union, "Trust, but verify." In some cases, just verify. Trust be damned.

Let's suppose that the worst thing you can do when reading nonfiction is to believe that everything you read is true. What's the second worst? *Not believing any of it.* One of the things my friend, now a professional in the world of books and publishing, learned along the way was that not every work of nonfiction can be relied on to deliver the truth, the whole truth, and that other

part. One possible outcome of such a revelation is cynicism; having had our eye blackened once, we believe that every outstretched hand will clench and punch us. That every book is either false or manipulative. That there is no truth to be found. But you know what? That jaded attitude is useless. Its logical endpoint is to dispense with reading altogether. For one thing, if we decide this about printed matter, is it possible to draw any other inference regarding mass media sources, news programs and news magazines and documentaries and all the rest? To say nothing of on-line sources, for heaven's sake. And then where are we? Stuck with novels, I suppose. At least we expect those to jerk us around in the service of art and entertainment. It would be a boon to fiction writers, who can use all the help they can get nowadays, but not that helpful for transmitting information. What we really need is not a thumbs-up or thumbs-down on the whole nonfiction enterprise but rather a means of navigating those tricky waters so that we don't capsize or pitch up on the rocks.

Being able to rely upon what we read is critical in many ways. Before the advent of the YouTube how-to video, most of us learned to do things from instructional books and articles. From those sources you could learn everything from throwing a discus to making household repairs to rebuilding car engines to mastering the art of French cooking, as promised by the late Julia Child and her coauthors. Say, that might be a good book title. And if you can learn to make *Coulis de Tomates à la Provençale* from a book, there's pretty much nothing that can't be learned there.

Beyond how-to instruction, there is a tremendous range of knowledge we rely on nonfiction to provide. We count on journalism, particularly local newspapers, to keep civic leaders and

institutions in check. When corruption—sweetheart deals in exchange for favorable policies, money for votes, campaign contributions for deep-sining regulatory rules—at city hall or the statehouse is uncovered, who uncovers it? Damn straight. When the holder of the highest office in the land hired a bunch of thugs in an attempt to subvert an election he was basically guaranteed to win anyway, who uncovered that vicious attack on our democratic institutions, who dug down to the truth despite threats and lies at every step? Two reporters from a local newspaper. Oh, sure, we think of the *Washington Post* as a major national paper and Bob Woodward and Carl Bernstein as stars in the journalistic firmament, but before Watergate they were just two young, and not very highly regarded, reporters at a local paper—whose locale just happened to contain the White House. The ability of journalists to investigate governmental wrongdoing rests on a foundation of trust: we have to be able to trust that they are giving the news to us straight, all truth and no fantasy, and they have to earn that trust with every story they write, every article they publish. That is why newspapers and magazines have traditionally insisted on multiple sources for facts in articles; the more explosive the story, the greater the need for solid facts. And it is why they are quick to admit mistakes and issue corrections. No human endeavor can be perfect, but for journalism to matter, it must come mighty close.

Nor is it just governmental wrongdoing that we count on *The Daily Herald-Star-Examiner* to apprise us of. Who broke open the story of sexual abuse in the Catholic Church? The *Boston Globe*, specifically a team called Spotlight, investigative reporters working together on stories of sufficient scope that they take months to uncover and publish. When they were finished, their list of pedophile priests had grown from one to thirteen to eighty-seven,

just in greater Boston. Numerous priests were removed from clerical duty, several were tried and convicted of abuse of minors, lawsuits were filed against the Archdiocese, and Cardinal Bernard Law, who had overseen the cover-ups for years, was forced by the weight of public opinion to resign his position. Throughout the process, the Spotlight team had to fight church and city red tape to open sealed documents and unearth carefully hidden evidence, while also fending off community resistance to the truth being revealed. It was attacked for making up stories or trading in false tales peddled by “disturbed” individuals. Yet they persisted, and their efforts were rewarded with the 2003 Pulitzer Prize for Public Service. And that, friends, is what journalism can do and why we need courageous nonfiction.

I recently read an article that reported the death of local newspapers—a process that has been going on for years—will mean that fewer instances of official malfeasance will be uncovered, which will be a national calamity. And so it will.

Every week brings us new reasons that we need professional journalists and investigative freelancers. The latest as I write is the misbehavior by Boeing in hiding the defects in its 737 MAX 8 jet, which caused two disastrous crashes in 2018 and 2019, one in Indonesia and the second in Ethiopia. The previous year, it was the horrific stories of Dr. Larry Nassar’s sexual abuse of girls and young women, mostly athletes, under the guise of treatment as a team doctor for USA Gymnastics and Michigan State University. Before that, it was the Flint water crisis, a series of bad decisions and shoddy processes that led to terrible water for residents of the city and lead poisoning for its children. That human-caused disaster also, however, involved the heroic efforts of a committed physician, Dr. Mona Hanna-Attisha, to reveal the problem despite

efforts to discredit her by state and local officials. Dr. Hanna-Attisha later augmented the reporting on the crisis with her own 2019 book, *What the Eyes Don’t See*. With all of these stories, the common thread is that none of the institutions involved willingly shared information about criminality or malfeasance. Reporters (and their lawyers) have to take journalistic sledgehammers to the stonewalling by companies and educational institutions and governments, because no entity cheerfully gives up incriminating evidence. This process of prying the information loose from unwilling hands is expensive, time-consuming, and not for the faint of heart.

The business of nonfiction, however, is not all gloom and doom. It can inspire, as did *The Boys in the Boat*, about the 1936 University of Washington rowing team that won the premier event and spoiled Hitler’s Olympics narrative as much as their brethren on the track, or *Seabiscuit*, about a cast-off horse, cast-off trainer, and cast-off jockey who came together to create the Thoroughbred sensation of the Great Depression. It can entertain and amuse, as do David Sedaris’s autobiographical essay-memoirs. It can pull back the curtain on moviemaking or rock and roll stardom, reveal the depths to which the human mind can sink or the heights to which it can ascend, unravel the mysteries of the universe or the inexplicable behavior of social organizations, explain the inner workings of the atom or the structure of ancient civilizations, expose horrific crimes from last week or a thousand years ago. In other words, it can offer us almost any knowledge the world has to offer. That’s all swell. It’s just that . . .

. . . we can’t always trust what nonfiction itself offers.

The same form that can unmask a hoax can also perpetrate

one. And has, with some regularity. If it can illuminate the workings of disease and its treatment, it can also be used to promote quackery and distract sufferers from legitimate information. It has equal facility to expose the sins of industry and to hide them or recast them as virtues. And here's the real problem: if we only read surfaces, we won't be able to tell the difference between the righteous and the right-around-the-bend.

There's a solution here: we can learn to read past the surface. To discern motive, to evaluate evidence, to analyze arguments, to avoid being hoodwinked. Such a reading program can give us greater appreciation of valid, and valuable, nonfiction while helping us to sweep the chaff away from the wheat.

I say it's high time we got started. How about you?

1

The Structure of Nonfiction Information

How We Find Out What We're Reading

I'M GOING TO ASK you here, to think like a writer for a little bit. Not what you signed up for, I know, but it will be worth it. Besides, you don't have to *actually* write anything. And let's talk here about longer-form nonfiction: magazine articles and books. The daily newspaper reporter is moving so fast that she rarely has time (or space) to concern herself with these matters. And what are we talking about? Salesmanship. Advertisements for yourself, or at least for your work. The first job of every writer on page one is to get the reader to page two, and then from two to three and so on. How do we do that?

By not sucking?

That would help. That's why the *hook*, that rhetorical or narrative gambit, is there at the front, something to win readers' goodwill and buy a little space to lay out the essentials of the work to follow. And how do writers manage that laying out of essentials?

The four Ps. Like the Five Ws of journalism, but fewer and with a different letter. Not Who, What, When, Where, and Why, but Problem, Promise, Program, and Platform. Not as catchy, but no less essential. These terms come up in writing book proposals and first chapters, but they also apply in magazine articles and books. Let's see what they mean.

- Problem: the prime cause that pushes the writer to commit this piece of nonfiction. You're establishing need here. If your article is on new and bizarre ways to use up zucchini in season, you want to establish that zucchini overpopulation is a menace to society, so we need all the help we can in eradicating this scourge. In *How to Read Poetry Like a Professor*, I made the claim that a great many readers fear poetry because they believe they can't understand it or the weird rules and terminology that accompany it. If you're writing a biography, the problem may simply be a lack of information: here is someone you never heard of, but that's been your loss because he's terrific and has much to teach us. Or the problem may be that there have been dozens of biographies of this famous person from the past, but the approaches have been inadequate to the task, or this newly revealed information changes everything. The nature of the problem matters less than your sales job about its importance for readers.
- Promise: in essence, "I can fix that for you." For the zucchini article, your promise is that these five new recipes will change readers' lives and rock their world. Heck, their kids won't even notice there's zucchini in there. In *Poetry*, my promise was that I would take the terror out of

poetry reading and actually make it fun by demystifying the form (avoiding *genre*, because that's part of the mystification). And also that they wouldn't notice the zucchini.

- Program: how the writer will achieve the promise. In the case of the magazine article, the program *is* the article, so next to zero space (a precious commodity) is given over to that. For the book writer, this is a big deal, how we go from promise to fulfillment. It goes, roughly, by examining this and then attaching it to that, we will achieve our aims. The historian or biographer will discuss methods and approach, the ways in which this specimen will differ from those earlier ones that, while laudable, couldn't quite achieve what this one will. For *Poetry*, I said that we would work first of all on simply getting the surface meaning of a new poem, from there working on figurative language and images and all those devices that make us uneasy as beginning (or returning) readers, and then we would examine the "grammar," the specialized set of rules by which poetry operates, by looking at a wide variety of poems from the very old to the quite new.
- Platform: your justification for stepping up on your soapbox. Who are you to tell us something new, anyway? Some people opt for expertise. In my "Like a Professor" books, I use the fact that I am, indeed, a professor with considerable experience teaching beginning literature students. A person writing a dog training book will probably allude to his forty years as a dog trainer, with numerous wins and placements to his credit. You haven't been creating award-winning recipes for forty years? That's okay, there are other platforms. Maybe you have

talked to expert cooks, gleaned tips that you then parlayed into new takes on old recipes or entirely new ones. The dog training book author may not be an expert at all but has interviewed fifteen of them to find the commonalities among their approaches. Or you can bluff your way through: "You don't know me from Adam, but when you taste these recipes, you'll be glad you read the article." Obviously, this approach has its greatest appeal on shorter pieces. It's hard to coax someone to read four hundred pages by saying, just wait till the end.

Why, then, did I ask you to think like a writer? So you can be a better informed reader. I believe it is best to know what strategies are being employed so that you can be more fully aware of a written work's structure. You already have a sense, when you read a first chapter, of where the book is going to go. Isn't it better to know why you have that sense, turning it from a vague feeling into concrete knowledge? That's what I thought.

Structural Design

WHEN WE DISCUSS FICTION, we frequently use the term *narrative strategy*, by which we mean the design plan wherein the writer arranges and releases information to the reader. Every writer has to have a plan, even if he claims not to have one. The plan usually comes ahead of the writing, but not always. Even so, the strategy becomes apparent in the eventual organization of that information. A writer such as William Faulkner can say that he merely trots around behind his characters with a notebook, writing down

what they do and say, but a point comes in the writing process when revision and rewriting replace drafting, and it is there that the novelist isn't trotting anywhere. Rather, he's stuck at his desk sweating details large and small, and some of those details involve whether the narrative strategy is working as it stands or needs some rearrangement.

Something similar happens in nonfiction, too. In fact, sometimes it isn't merely like narrative design, it *is* narrative design. That's because some nonfiction is narrative in nature—some, but not all. Some is expository, some argumentative, some informational, and much a combination of one or more of these types of writing. So rather than gum up the works with a term borrowed from another genre that only sometimes applies in this one, let's go with a more generic term, *structural design*. As we read a work of nonfiction, we want to notice not only what that design is, but how the writer achieves it.

As an example, let's take two of the most successful sports books of this century, Laura Hillenbrand's *Seabiscuit: An American Legend* (2001) and Daniel James Brown's *The Boys in the Boat: Nine Americans and Their Epic Quest for Gold at the 1936 Berlin Olympics* (2013). At first glimpse, they might not seem to have a great deal to do with each other. One is about a horse, the other about a group of boys turning into men one stroke of the oar at a time. Stripping away the surface difference, however, we see that they share a lot of similarities. Each is a multiparty tale in which the backgrounds, successes and failures, and ambitions of the parties matter immensely to the outcome for the participants and therefore to readers' understanding. Each story is set against the background of the era, the Great Depression and, in the latter, the rise of Adolf Hitler's Nazi Party. And each

has a cast of hard-luck characters. Seabiscuit, jockey Red Pollard, trainer Tom Smith, and owner Charles S. Howard all struggle to overcome setbacks and personal failings. Smith, for instance, was down to one horse when Howard, on a blind recommendation, hired him to train the temperamental stallion who despite blazing speed seemed to invent ways to lose races. And Pollard, who had his own long list of races lost (and few won), was a brawler and a heavy drinker before reforming himself as part of the task of managing his difficult mount.

Those boys in the boat, eight rowers and a coxswain, came from hardscrabble backgrounds, the most severe adolescence belonging to Joe Rantz, abandoned by his father and stepmother at age twelve and left to make his way in the woods of the Northwest. Additionally, a story about rowing must focus on the coach and any other central figures. In this case the coach was Al Ulbrickson, a hugely talented rower in his own right but a frustrated coach who found his Washington Huskies always lagging behind the powerhouse University of California Golden Bears, while the seminal figure was shell-building genius George Yeoman Pocock, who doubled as a father-confessor and Zen master of the boathouse. He, too, had his own backstory of difficulties and setbacks. And looming over everything is the desperation of the Great Depression and the gathering geopolitical clouds in Europe.

In narratives of such widely varying figures, it is hardly surprising that the authors choose strategies that lean toward the kaleidoscopic, shifting from character to character and event to event with each new chapter, and sometimes even within chapters. After a scene-setting preface (Hillenbrand) or prologue (Brown)—the differences between those terms being largely one

of personal preference—the authors use early chapters to introduce the key personnel and situations in their stories. Hillenbrand begins not with Seabiscuit himself but with chapters on the self-made, automobile-dealing millionaire Howard, followed by taciturn trainer Smith, and then the feisty jockey Pollard. Only once she has her human livestock safely in the stable, as it were, does she introduce the horse. For his part, Brown also devotes his first chapter to management, to Coach Ulbrickson, then gives one to the earliest days of Joe Rantz, followed by a third devoted chiefly to the enigmatic Pocock, before returning in chapter four to Rantz and his backwoods marooning. In each book, once we reach the end of the fourth chapter, the narrative die has been cast, and the telling will follow the now-established pattern.

It's worth noting that such a structure is not inevitable, not dictated by the material. There would be other ways to organize the information. One could easily, for instance, keep the focus on the main character, whether equine or human, so that every chapter is about Seabiscuit or Joe, with other characters being relegated to second-tier importance as they elbow their way into chapters that follow a single-minded storyline. Handled this way, the books become straight biographies of single beings. Nothing innately wrong with that. In the case of *Seabiscuit*, the title wouldn't even need changing. Brown, on the other hand, might have needed to rename his *The Boy in the Boat and the Eight Others Who Helped Him to Glory*, which is somewhat less satisfying. Or accurate. Neither, however, would be the book we have. Or anything nearly as interesting. The point is, a steady through-line narrative would significantly change the focus and the *telos* of the work. "Telos" comes from Greek and means "goal" or "endpoint." In this case, think of the change in structural design effectively

moving the goalposts. The actual structure has a lot of advantages for these books reaching their desired endpoints. The shifting focuses allow for development of multiple characters, while the largely single focus within chapters keeps that development from being chaotic or overly diffused.

In the case of *The Boys in the Boat*, the structural design has one added benefit: it avoids reader burnout. Joe's story is sufficiently harrowing in its perils-of-Pauline details that lingering there extensively could prove gloomier than some of us could bear. Brown is wise enough to take readers up to the point of pain, then end the chapter and move on to another topic before continuing that story. This angle applies chiefly to his childhood, but since that occupies the first part of the book, which is also when people decide whether or not to continue reading, it carries outsized importance.

But what about a book with a different subject entirely, one that doesn't rely on narrative of a group? Maybe a self-help book? I'm not sure if David Brooks's *The Road to Character* (2015) exactly fits the genre, but it has to do with self-improvement. He takes as his starting point the admission that he has plenty of room to improve, declaring that "I was born with a natural disposition toward shallowness," and calling himself "a narcissistic blowhard," hardly surprising for a newspaper "pundit and columnist." What he seeks, then, are examples of other people who have managed to surmount their own natural dispositions to become better versions of themselves. What sort of structural design strategy will carry his search forward and interest readers? That's the question.

He opens the book with an introduction that states the main

problem: human duality. Taking his terms from Rabbi Joseph Soloveitchik's 1965 book, *The Lonely Man of Faith*, he calls these two sides "Adam I" and "Adam II." Adam I is busy, ego-driven, successful perhaps, but self-involved. He embodies what Brooks calls "résumé virtues," those achievement items like high grades or test scores, sales figures, professional accomplishments—not bad in themselves (taken in moderation, one supposes), but hardly expressing the whole of human possibility. Adam II, by contrast, is characterized by mastery over the self, or perhaps over the ego, and his strengths are "eulogy virtues," things like kindness, compassion, honesty, faithfulness that we hope will be spoken of at our funerals. From there he launches into the book proper with a first chapter that elaborates on the dichotomy he has set up between the two Adams, along with plenty of examples from recent decades that indicate why we need to cultivate Adam II. What follows from that is a series of eight chapters, each focusing on one or at most two persons—the journalist and social activist Dorothy Day, President Dwight Eisenhower, General George Marshall, writers George Eliot and Samuel Johnson, and quarterbacks Johnny Unitas and Joe Namath—demonstrating the weaknesses of character that each struggled to overcome. Each chapter is a narrative in its own right that demonstrates what one might call (although Brooks does not) the Deadly Sin that held the person back or the Cardinal Virtue that helped him or her surmount the character deficit. The final chapter is both a summation and a fifteen-point recap for those who might have had difficulty gleaning the lessons from the foregoing chapters. On that, readers may be forgiven: Brooks is reticent about pushing his lessons, sometimes to the point of obscurity. In general, however, he makes his case fairly clearly. And his final list, if not

absolutely necessary, will be welcomed by many readers simply for bringing his numerous conclusions together in one place.

The beauty of this book is that we need not wonder about the structural design; Brooks lays it out for us at the end of the introduction. In a section called "The Plan," no less. Oh, if only every book were so, right? Actually, most are, if not quite as baldly stated as this one. Authors for the most part do not wish for readers to be confused or to feel lost, so if we read with just a little bit of care, we generally understand where the book is headed by the end of the introduction and completely by the conclusion of the first chapter.

Some books have a very straightforward structural design. Stephen E. Ambrose's *Undaunted Courage: Meriwether Lewis, Thomas Jefferson, and the Opening of the American West* (1996) follows Meriwether Lewis from birth to death in chronological order, bringing Jefferson into view only when his presence explains how Lewis became the front half of "and Clark" and what that remarkable tandem achieved. We are not surprised by such a strategy; it is the natural state of historical biography, and he or she who would tell a life in some other order will have to offer a certain amount of justification to readers. It can certainly be managed otherwise, but the writer needs a pretty compelling reason.

The point of these examples is that every writer has a plan for his or her book, and we will understand the book—and often something about the writer—better by noting that plan, by observing the strategy by which the information is delivered to readers. We'll get back to the specifics of structure in a bit. For now, it's enough to know that every book, every article, every column has one, even the ones that purport to have none. Chaos can be structural, right?

2

The Ecology of the Nonfiction Biosphere

Or, Who Writes What, When

LET'S SAY, STRICTLY FOR the sake of argument, that you want to read a work of nonfiction. We know that, in the real world, you may not have a lot of choice, that the purpose may be driven not by desire but by compulsion. You have a school assignment. Or a work assignment. Or a need to keep up with (or begin to have) basic knowledge in a field. Sometimes, you really don't have a choice. But humor me and pretend that you do and that your choice is to read that item. Which can also be true even if you're being forced to do it. You might, say, want to do well in the course or get a promotion or not look like an idiot when you speak before the school board. There are lots of reasons to want to read something even when the impetus is not your own desire.

Here's the good news: every form of human communication has a basic grammar, a set of rules of the road that will govern how information is offered to readers. So if you understand that

grammar, that set of rules and practices, you can make your way down that road a little faster. Swell so far, right? It's just that . . .

You have to know the form to know the grammar. Part of that identification is fairly easy: if you see a broadsheet format in multiple sections, that's probably a newspaper. But not all parts of the morning paper are the same; news articles follow different rules from features, which are in turn different from opinion/editorial content. Happily, the third of those occupies a separate part of the paper—usually the last page or two of the front section—and the first two sometimes have separate sections. We'll discuss that further in a while, but on with the problem! Magazines, like newspapers, appear at regular, defined intervals (normally weekly or monthly rather than daily), but they have sets of rules of their own. I say "sets" because magazines also publish a variety of forms in their pages. And books have a host of grammars. Is the book you just picked off the shelf history, biography, how-to, self-help, memoir, essay, current affairs, nonfiction narrative, journalism, New Journalism, travel, arts, true crime, psychology, spirituality, or philosophy? There will be many points of overlap, but they will all follow their own rules and policies.

Take, oh, history versus New Journalism or what is now often called participatory journalism, the sort of writing pioneered by Hunter S. Thompson, Tom Wolfe, Joan Didion, and John McPhee. In both sorts of writing there will be an emphasis on accuracy; that is, the writer is obliged to report what was actually said and done, while avoiding putting words in anyone's mouth or inventing actions in a sort of what-if speculation. Whether the trip is undertaken by Lewis and Clark in Ambrose's *Undaunted Courage* or Ken Kesey and his Merry Pranksters in Tom Wolfe's *The Electric Kool-Aid Acid Test* (1968), readers want to know that

the text is accurately reporting what went on back in the mists of time. Or just last year. So there's one similarity. Another is that in both genres, writers should reward readers by being somewhat interesting. This expectation would not be inevitably valid, by the way, for academic histories—or books in a lot of other academic fields from mathematics to sociology to, yes, literary criticism. Academic readers, prompted by professional concerns, will often put up with boring or downright bad writing if the insights or new information are sufficiently compelling. More's the pity: they are afforded ample opportunities to practice such forgiveness. Lay readers, on the other hand, should not be expected to suffer unduly just to acquire a little information. My experience is that they are pretty good sports about minor suffering, but they have their limits.

This distinction raises an "interesting" question: how engaging is engaging enough? For Ambrose, it seems, the material is so compelling that he has only to stand to one side. We're talking *Alice in Wonderland* with grizzly bears. This new world was a fantasy land. With the threat of sudden, violent death. Get out of the way; let the story tell itself. Don't clutter it up with excess analysis. Don't get between the reader and the explorers' astonishment and elation and terror. Don't try to be the star of the show. Ambrose's claim to authority is the mass of scholarship that lies behind his narrative. He need not press an argument that he is an authority; the better strategy is to let that mountain of learning speak for itself. Wolfe has a different problem: there is no mass of scholarship precisely because the phenomenon in *Electric Kool-Aid* is so new. This is First Contact with Aliens. The only way to intimate any sort of expertise or authority is to get on the inside, to worm his way into the unworldly culture. A

relatively transparent narrative approach will never do. Instead, Wolfe makes his narrative persona the star of the show: preening, smart-alecky, hip, clever, judgmental, ironic, linguistically ostentatious, simultaneously involved and detached. By making his narrative filter manifest, he becomes a tour guide or maybe a carnival barker for this collection of oddities. He wants us to be taken with *Electric Kool-Aid*'s main cast—Kesey and his crew—but not to be taken in by them. His stratagem has the paradoxical effect of seeming to bring us inside the group while at the same time inoculating us against the most damaging excesses to be found there.

We'll go into requirements for specific nonfiction genres in more detail a bit later. For now, we need only remember that the rules aren't set based on the physical form, the *codex*, but by the type of contents that form presents.

Types of Writing in Your Morning Paper

ONE OF THE THINGS we need to learn as readers is how to manage our expectations. By "manage," I don't mean "reduce." Rather, if we're going to get the most from our reading, we need to learn which expectations are appropriate for which types of writing. Remember those sections of the newspaper? Let's go back there and see what we can see. A newspaper is a diverse neighborhood. Lots of different sorts of writing coexist in close proximity. True, the comics page and the editorial page are isolated in their own quarters, not quite walled off but nearly so. More like chain link than cinder block, but behind barriers nonetheless. Whether this is to protect those two places or the rest of the paper from con-

ragion via close contact is hard to say. What other writing do we find in those pages? *Hard news* stories, the just-the-facts-ma'am, who-what-when-where-why meat and potatoes of news gathering. *Features* are often longer (unless news items are large-scale exposés) and softer as to subject matter and reportorial stance. They may range from human interest tales, oddball topics, remembrances of businesses long gone or prospects for those just opening, beautiful-home stories, the kinds of pieces usually cast as *soft news*. Most can be said to lie along a continuum between hard news reporting and public relations news releases. The home beautiful articles, for instance, are sometimes glorified real estate listings, complete in recent years with asking prices for the properties. Ongoing *columns* are another category (or maybe several categories). We may think of recurring columns as synonymous with op-ed pieces by syndicated or in-house writers, because many of those are (a) columns and (b) recurring, but there are many other types. Certain columnists take human interest features as their beat. These columns are sometimes concurrent with *ombudsperson* type items. That is, the columnist will take reader input about being wronged by companies or government, ferret out the most truthful version she can find, and try to set things right by acting as intermediary between the parties or by playing the public scold to shame the wrongdoers into doing a little bit more right. The columnist will assume the mantle of Avenging Angel on, say, Monday, Wednesday, and Friday, interspersed with Seeker of Interesting Neighbors on Sunday, Tuesday, and Thursday. Or she may do something entirely personal, something like my-life-in-the-community reflection pieces in which she contemplates nature, her family, her dogs, and maybe the night sky. That's okay, though: being an Avenging Angel is tough work.

Is that all papers have to offer? Not at all. They offer *reviews* (books, movies, television shows, dance and theater performances) and *previews* (upcoming programs on television). They carry specialized *advice columns*, usually by national figures, on relationship problems or questions about finance. They provide, perhaps less often than formerly, the previous day's stock market numbers, for which there may or may not be accompanying analyses. There are *travel pieces*, which may be reviews or features, designed to lure us at least in imagination to far-off places. And there are *letters* from readers, wherein we meet some of the more thoughtful and, occasionally, less securely hinged neighbors.

A fully functioning newspaper, aside from rapidly becoming a rare commodity, is an astonishing compilation not only of writing but of *types* of writing.

Where is the one place in the paper where all of these categories find a home? The Sports section. The front page or two will usually be taken up with straight reporting, hard news for sports fans. The purest form of hard reporting in the sports pages is the *box score*, a specialized reading challenge. To the uninitiated, a box score is a jumble of names and numbers signifying nothing. To the cognoscenti, on the other hand, it is a way to reconstruct a ball game from a list of abstractions. Sadly, one of the victims of reduced income and squeezed space in contemporary papers is precisely that box score. It may be a minor loss in an age when all of the information can be found somewhere online, but the beauty of the traditional model is that all of these things appeared in a single section of the dailies. But that's not all. There will often be sports features, particularly in the Sunday edition, and most papers still employ local columnists and import syndicated columnists for commentary on national stories. And those

columns will have more than a little opinion in them. Indeed, for sheer contentiousness, the Editorial page has nothing on Sports. It's the section that can stand as a microcosm for the entire paper.

Why does it matter what kinds of writing appear in a newspaper? Because each of them demands a slightly different reading strategy. In part, it's about pace. I mentioned a bit ago that features are more leisurely and ease their way into their material. In a straight news piece, the famous Five Ws—who, what, when, where, and why—are frontloaded, more often than not in the first paragraph. Some folks append an H, how, to those five elements, or even substitute “how” for “why,” but I think “how” is what the rest of the article is about. The *lede* (or, *lead* in some journalistic quarters) paragraph is the thumbnail of the event being described in the article; the rest is explanation, filling in the blank spots until a complete picture emerges. If you read a feature with the same expectations for rate of revelation, you are bound to be disappointed. The lede in a feature is often a tease. It may be a hint of difficulties to come (“As Larry Davidson sat at the traffic light, he could little imagine the life change coming his way”) or a picture of an endpoint (“Back at his workbench, Larry Davidson is happy to once again handle his drawknives and chisels”). Actually, if you published those two together, readers could probably assemble the story for themselves, but that would defeat the purpose of a feature. You cannot, however, figure out the facts of the story from the lede alone—at least, not in a soft news story.

It's hard to keep these various types of newspaper writing sorted. Even the pros have difficulty sometimes. In discussing a hugely viral fake news item from 2016, Professors Cailin O'Connor and James Owen Weatherall in their otherwise terrific *The*

Misinformation Age (2019) compare it to an “article” in the *Washington Post* that, by comparison with the phony tale, was shared over one hundred thousand times fewer, even though it was the most shared among legitimate media pieces. Just one problem: the article in question was actually a column by *Post* opinion writer Paul Waldman. They further identify the piece as “nakedly partisan,” “hardly ‘news’ at all in the standard sense.” Of course not. By definition, a column is not a news item; it is an opinion piece, here as is customary identified as such and printed on the opinion page. We wouldn’t criticize a news article for lacking an opinion, would we? I so hope you said no.

Wait a minute. You keep acting like newspapers are critical to a good life. But they’ve been dying for a while now, and life goes on. Just how critical are they?

I suppose that’s up to us, and sadly, a lot of us have voted. Newspapers used to be a good deal longer than they are now. Gradually, through the final third of the twentieth century, many—not all—readers lost interest in the in-depth articles, the long exposés, and just the sheer length of the morning (or afternoon) *Daily-Journal-Tribune-Herald-Globe-World-State-Country-Times-News*. Along about that time, in 1982, either responding to or anticipating declining interest, the Gannett Company published a new sort of national newspaper, *USA Today*. Articles were shorter, punchier, largely stripped of context, more focused on graphics and photos, nearly as much color as the Sunday funnies, and written in simpler language than the flagship dailies such as the *New York Times* or *Boston Globe*. Readers could breeze right through it. It became the lightning-round first rough draft of history. As you can guess, the new creature provoked strong reaction. The critics, who were legion, hated it, called it McPaper

or “television you can wrap fish in,” and suggesting that the fish-wrapping was its highest best use. They also predicted that *USA Today* would lead to the demise of the daily newspaper. Others hailed it as a breath of fresh air in a stale news environment that hadn’t kept up with the times or taken readers’ wishes into account. As you can also guess, it caught on with the public. Although it, too, has experienced readership decline, its daily subscription sales as of late 2017 were just under a million daily. Add to that the number of local Gannett papers that include a section from the mother ship as well as the various mobile device apps and searchable content, and the daily total climbs much higher, possibly as much as seven million. My own local paper has long since ceased to carry national or international content from traditional wire services in favor of *USA Today* content and has more recently dropped syndicated columnists and national sports stories in favor of Gannett-originated writing. The changes cannot be called improvements, and the paper has continued to shrink. It does, however, still publish every day, something not a lot of journals can claim.

Because of the ceaseless work of journalists, newspapers (or some electronic version thereof) will continue to occupy an *essential niche* in the nonfiction environment. We still want hard news, personal interest features, game results, movie reviews, articles on music trends, obituaries, police blotter reports. And where else are you going to get those in one place? Social media? Not very likely. Sure, Facebook will have lots of stories on the death of a disgraced politician or a movie star in her prime, but not the one for your aunt Mabel or your neighbor’s father. Moreover, we, or at least some of us, would prefer those reviews, those backstage stories, that analysis be written by someone who actually knows

something. Including how to write. The quality of a great deal of online information is simply dreadful, and sometimes far from true, however passionately presented. So that's why I would suggest that those niches are in fact essential.

Okay, then, but why do we need all these different forms of publication? You know, newspapers and blogs and magazines and books. I mean, what's the point?

That's easy: time. The thing of which there is never enough. That heals all wounds or possibly wounds all heels.

Time? You sure?

Absolutely. Don't forget the maxim that "journalism is the first rough draft of history," often attributed to Philip L. Graham of the *Washington Post* (whose death allowed his widow, Katharine, to succeed him as publisher and be played by Meryl Streep in *The Post*). The reality is that Alan Barth, also of the *Post*, had said the same thing in a book review in *The New Republic* in 1943, and he may not have been the first. In any case, the bromide has rattled around long enough in the culture to be pretty widespread by now. What does that mean? Chiefly, that the news is the first indication most of us have that something large or small has happened. In the old days, a major event—a sudden death, say, or an explosion at a factory—that took place in the morning would be in a large city paper's evening edition. You can tell that was the old days by the fact that papers had multiple editions when needed. Nowadays, it would be in *tomorrow's* edition, which is still pretty fast. The name of the journalistic game is speed, at which papers excel. What they sacrifice in the headlong rush to publish is context. Between late afternoon, when our putative event takes place, and around eleven o'clock that night when the editors put the paper to bed (an old expression meaning,

send it downstairs to the printers and pressmen), there is precious little time to establish context. That's okay, though: there will be other days on which the writers can provide more background, more insights, more context.

Which is also the job of magazines. Even a weekly magazine can't possibly compete with the dailies for speed of reporting. And a monthly magazine? Forget it. So what do we need those for? Other kinds of stories. Many monthlies have never been interested in news or current affairs reporting, because by the time an issue appears, news is old and stale. Even news in a weekly is likely to be several days old at best, and in the age of the twenty-four-hour news cycle, several days might as well be years. What, then, can a magazine provide if not news? Perspective. Analysis. Context. Those things take time. Obviously, the perspective gained through three or four weeks is hardly that of three or four decades, but it is enough perspective that we can think of it as a second draft of history: a little less rough, a little more fleshed out, a little more shapely. *Time*, *Newsweek*, *The New Republic*, *The New Yorker*, *The Atlantic*, *Harper's*, *Life*, *Look*—those are among the classic weekly and monthly magazines with an interest in current affairs. The first two are full-on news magazines. Others take news coverage as part of their mission. Several rely on a good deal of commentary. They all provide greater context and perspective than is possible in daily journalism. A couple, *Life* and *Look*, were famous for the addition of lots of photographs to the public record. All of them, whatever their publication schedule, shared with papers the unforgiving deadlines that sometimes cause incomplete stories to be dropped at the last moment or cut off at the knees to publish what has been constructed thus far. Better, more complete, more contextualized. But not complete.

Nor are magazines interested only in current event and political coverage as their contribution to the historical record. Many periodicals come under the heading of *specialty* journalism. These are magazines devoted to every sort of human activity, from cooking to model trains to landscaping to fly-fishing. But only one of those activities per journal, which is what the "specialty" term suggests; they stick absolutely to their special field of interest. Anyone looking for political reporting in *Martha Stewart Living* or the *Pointing Dog Journal* will find they have made a wrong turn in their search. Others, like several of those I listed above, are *general interest* magazines, meaning that they publish a variety of types of stories on many different subjects. In *The New Yorker*, an article on the opening of the latest Broadway show may reside next to one on the environmental hazards of copper mining. Not everyone will approach those two stories with the same enthusiasm, which is one reason that general interest magazines have dwindled from the most common type in the middle of the last century to a mere handful. At the same time, this eclectic approach holds appeal precisely for the surprises it offers. Few readers expected, upon opening the April 27, 1987 issue of *The New Yorker*, that they would be attracted by an examination of the history of dynamite, much less a two-parter that stretched into the following week's issue, yet that is what Bryan Di Salvatore's fascinating "Vehement Fire" offered them.

So here's a question: if journalism is the first rough draft of history, where does the final draft find a home?

In histories.

{ Building Blocks of Argument }

Claims, Grounds, Warrants

THE FIELD OF NONFICTION has just as many, and very likely more, genres than does fiction. Instead of horror, detective, historical romance, psychological realism, and so forth, it gives us biography, history, how-to, political analysis, sociology, art history, and a whole lot more. But with the exception of *reportage* (the reporting of events in the truest form possible)—and that is limited largely to daily newspapers and a smattering of weekly magazines whose numbers continue to diminish—the actual form of all of these is *argument*, the attempt to convince readers or listeners that the writers' angle is the correct one. Comparatively few biographers have the luxury of writing the only life of their subject. So each succeeding one sets out the same argument: this version is superior to all preceding versions in ways X, Y, and Z. The most common argument for superiority is completist: recently discovered information (a trove of letters not previously known, documents

previously held in trust but now available to the public, synthesis of all the competing prior biographies of the subject) makes it possible for me to be more thorough, more detailed, and a whole lot longer. There is a much smaller subset whose argument is the opposite: these massive bios have gotten out of hand, so here is one that gives you the facts without all the palaver. Usually there is a swell of competing biographies when a new hoard of documents is opened to scholars. There was a biographical stampede not unlike the Oklahoma land rush when the Ernest Hemingway Collection became available at the John F. Kennedy Presidential Library and Museum in Boston in the mid-1970s. Suddenly a wealth of new material presented itself for examination, and the race was on. And almost as suddenly, Carlos Baker's definitive biography, *Ernest Hemingway: A Life Story*, was a good deal less definitive. Now each new Life of Hem could draw on this wealth of previously unknown or unconfirmed details, which was swell. But they also had to make the case as to why *this* life was better than the last, better than any of the others, and certainly better than poor old Baker.

This sort of thing happens in other fields as well, but our thoughts here are for argument as a form, and for reading same. Those can range from sidebar claims in an otherwise nonargumentative work to editorials and opinions in papers and magazines to whole books making a fairly global set of claims. The success of argument, whatever the scale, rests on *proof*, on making your points and then making them stick not just for those who agree with you but for those who would disagree.

I'm not crazy about specialized terms. Jargon is just so . . . jargony. Well, sometimes it can't be helped, and this is one of

those times. There are three words that we can't live without in discussing argument: *claims*, *grounds*, and *warrants*. Hey, don't blame me, these are from philosopher Stephen Toulmin's *The Uses of Argument* (1958), a book that changed the way we talk, and maybe think, about argument—and not only by hanging three new terms around our necks. A *claim* is sometimes called a “conclusion” or even a “thesis” (and a thesis statement in a deductive essay is typically a type of claim), but we might best think of it as an assertion. If someone tells you that she is an American citizen, then that is her claim, and, were there any real need, it would be up to her to prove it. A *ground* is a fact, piece of data, or other evidence that will be used to buttress the claim. In this case, our friend's ground is that she was born in Guam. But on their own a claim and a ground are just two strangers standing next to each other at a dance; if you want them to go steady, you have to pin them together. That act of pinning is called a *warrant*. The question that the warrant needs to address is the one that may have occurred to you: why Guam? So here's her answer: “Guam is an American territory, and the fourteenth amendment to the Constitution guarantees birthright citizenship for all persons born in the United States, including its incorporated territories.” Now the claim and the ground have a real relationship compliments of the warrant.

At its most basic level, a warrant is simply the act of logically connecting an assertion (the claim) with its supporting evidence (the ground): the supporting evidence I'm using to support my assertion provides that support because of *X* and *Y*, and here's how it does that. In that sense, a great deal of writing is like court arguments. If you as the attorney make an assertion and present

evidence to support it, you're only partway there; without tying those two things together with ropes of logic and reason, all is lost.

There are three areas where an argument can go sideways. You may have heard of them: the claim, the ground, and the warrant. The claim can be lacking in real support or badly stated or inept in some other way. The ground can be false. False facts are never good, but they do happen. Unlike the claim, the ground can be fact-checked because it's—what?—presented as a fact. If our friend's ground is that she was born in American Samoa, we can quickly discover that while it is a territory, it is not one of the territories where birthright citizenship is offered. The warrant, for its part, can be flawed, illogical, mistaken. In forty years of teaching college students about writing, I saw every way warrants can go wrong, as well as a thousand times as many ways they can go right.

This discussion barely scratches the claims-department surface. Toulmin, being a philosopher, has a number of other terms: *backing*, *qualifier*, *rebuttal* among them, but we'd really rather not get lost in the argumentative weeds, and these are the big three for our purposes. So next time you're reading or watching or listening to an argument, keep them in mind. They'll show you what's true and help you filter out a good deal of nonsense.

3

The Power of the Prologue

That Funny Thing Up Front

WHAT'S ALL THIS BUSINESS that happens before a book begins? I mean, forewords, prefaces, introductions, and prologues—who needs 'em? And why are there so many? To the first question, you do, fellow reader. And so do I. And to the second, they are multiple because of different functions. First, the easy one: "introduction" doesn't mean anything except "up front." It can be part of an article or book, labeled or not, written by the author or someone else, be part of the text of the book proper (that is, it will appear in every edition ever) or an appendix specific only to the edition at hand. If you're like me, you may have spent much of your early academic career skipping intros by outsiders to get to the meaty part. That would be a mistake, but it rarely proves fatal.

From here, things get more specific, if not clearer to the civilian. Here's the interesting thing: forewords, prefaces, and